

and field lover. I took the next morning off to rest, but by the evening, I was back at the stadium. Watching. Cheering. Supporting. Living the sport in its purest form.

The very next day, the men's high jump final was scheduled. India's brightest hope, Sarvesh, was competing, and I was there, loud and proud in support. But equally important was witnessing Sanghyeok Woo perform in front of his home crowd in Korea. What a show he put on — every jump felt like a celebration of sport.

Later that evening, I watched Avinash Sable cruise to a dominant gold in the steeplechase — so smooth, so in control. And then came Jyothi Yarraji's incredible gold in the hurdles. Her surge between hurdles 7 to 10 was a masterclass in both technique and tenacity. She didn't just win — she snatched it.

There were many unforgettable moments, but two stand out. One was the night of the women's high jump final. That morning, I got a message from Pooja (right) — "You better be at the stadium tonight." I even got a call from her coach, Balwan Singh reminding me.

Pooja, to me, is the next big thing in Indian athletics. She's fearless. As she moved through her warm-up, I noticed something different. Gone was the pronounced hop in the middle of her approach. Instead, she was attacking the curve with a speed and rhythm I hadn't seen before. I walked up to her and said, "The only thing that can come between you and a medal is you yourself. Keep doing what you're doing — you've got this."

She didn't need me after that. She didn't need anyone. Her coach had done his job. And she was ready. A double personal best at just 18 and a continental title? That's not potential — that's power. That's presence. That's a flex.

The second moment was quieter — but just as powerful. It was the night before the men's javelin final. I had just returned to the hotel after Pooja's competition, and when I connected to Wi-Fi, I saw multiple missed calls from Sachin Yadav's (right) physio. I called back

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immediately. "Nothing urgent," he said, "but Sachin wants to talk." When Sachin came to my room, he looked calm on the outside. He's a towering guy — even taller than me — but I could see the nerves in his eyes. This was his first big international meet. Expectations were high. Pressure was heavy.

Before he could even say anything, I said, "Let's go get ice cream." That was it. No motivational speeches. No deep strategy.

Just a breather. A small moment to forget the weight of the world and remember that he belongs here.

The next day? He launched a *monster*. Just centimetres shy of beating the Olympic champion. It wasn't just a medal, but it was a statement: **he's coming**.

The one thing I truly realised at this Asian Championships is that the Indian athletics team of this decade feels very different. I saw myself in transition — from being the young rookie who made senior teams at 17, like Pooja is now, to becoming one of the older guys in the squad at 27. But one thing hasn't changed: my intention has always been to go out of my way to make the younger ones feel welcome. Because I remember what it was like to be in their shoes a few years back — unsure if I belonged, quietly doubting myself.

The truth is, if you've made the team, you've already done something right. You *do* belong. And sometimes, reminding someone of that doesn't take a motivational speech. Sometimes, it's as simple as showing up, sharing space, and grabbing an ice cream.

I'm genuinely excited about the kind of athletes coming out of India right now — brave, talented, and hungry. This isn't a one-off. This is just the beginning for Indian athletics.



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